GBL

Generating Better Livelihoods
for Grant Recipients

www.finmark.org.za/GBL/



What helps young people move from surviving to building a livelihood?

Relational livelihood support in practice

Participant insights summary from the Generating Better Livelihoods for Grant Recipients pilot

3A

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INSIDE

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Overview

Livelihood progression cannot be driven by a single intervention. It depends on the interaction between people, support systems, resources and the opportunities available to them. This is the clearest message emerging from the Generating Better Livelihoods for Grant Recipients (GBL) participant research.

Training, referrals and access to funding matter. However, on their own, they do not enable people to build sustainable livelihoods. Participants also need someone to help them navigate opportunities, encouragement to keep going, practical support to overcome barriers, and the confidence to act.

This is where the relational nature of the GBL matters. The evidence suggests that relationships should not be considered an additional feature of the model. Instead, they form part of the mechanism through which participants move from being aware of an opportunity to accessing it, participating in it and, ultimately, converting it into livelihood progress.

At the same time, the research shows that relationships and support cannot overcome structural constraints on their own. Weak local economies, limited resources and household pressures continue to shape what is possible.

This is important for how we think about the future of GBL, and what conditions are needed for it to work better and at scale.

Background

GBL is a pilot initiative designed to connect Child Support Grant (CSG) and COVID-19 Social Relief of Distress (SRD) recipients to pathways into employment, entrepreneurship and further skills development. It adapts the globally recognised BRAC Graduation Model to the South African context, linking social protection to a structured pathway towards economic inclusion.

The model brings together several forms of support: asset transfers for productive livelihoods, linkages to employment opportunities, support for basic needs, and intensive coaching. This integrated approach recognises that people living in poverty require more than a single intervention. It is designed to provide sustained, coordinated support that helps participants build resilience, confidence and viable income-generating opportunities.

Coaching is one of the GBL's most important innovations. Linkages Facilitators based at implementation sites provide ongoing, practical support to participants, helping them navigate the different components of the programme, pursue livelihood opportunities and respond to challenges along the way. This coaching function provides continuity between the different forms of support and helps translate them into a more sustained livelihood journey.

The programme is led by the Department of Social Development (DSD) and its agencies, the South African Social Security Agency (SASSA) and the National Development Agency (NDA), and is implemented by FinMark Trust with technical support from BRAC International.

THE MODEL BRINGS TOGETHER

Asset transfers for productive livelihoods

Linkages to employment opportunities

Support for basic needs

Intensive coaching



This summary draws on qualitative research conducted by the Centre for Social Development in Africa (CSDA) at the University of Johannesburg (UJ). It examines participants' experiences before and during their engagement with GBL: where they started, what they experienced, what changed, and what continued to hold them back.

The purpose is to understand what participants' experiences tell us about how livelihood support works in practice, and what this means for continued investment, institutionalisation and scale.

48 INTERVIEWS | **7** PILOT SITES | **3** PROVINCES

How the insights were generated

The findings are based on 48 semi-structured interviews with GBL participants across seven pilot sites in KwaZulu-Natal, Gauteng and the Free State.

The research deliberately included participants who had experienced different levels of progression. This included people who had successfully accessed opportunities, as well as those who had struggled to establish linkages or had disengaged.

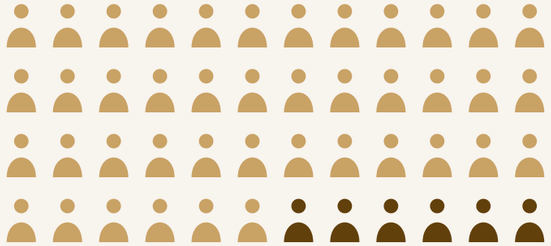
This is important because it means the evidence does not present only the programme's strongest outcomes. It provides a more realistic picture of what GBL is achieving, where it is helping, and where the wider environment continues to constrain participants.

Participants were asked about their lives before joining GBL, why they joined, the support they received, their interactions with Linkage Facilitators and Champions[1], changes they experienced, and the barriers that remained.

[1] Linkages Facilitators are the coaches employed by GBL and Linkages Champions are SASSA officials who were nominated to support the GBL's coaching function.

Who we heard from

48
Participants interviewed



42 Women | **6** Men

7 sites
KwaZulu-Natal, Gauteng and Free State

3 — **KwaZulu-Natal**
- KwaMashu
- Mthwalume
- Madadeni

2 — **Gauteng**
- Randfontein
- Sebokeng

2 — **Free State**
- Meloding/Saaiplaas
- Oppermansdorp

Where participants started

Livelihood insecurity is not only about employment

Participants did not join the GBL with a single problem that could be addressed through a job, a business or a training course. Their experiences reflected a combination of interrupted education, caregiving responsibilities, household poverty, trauma, domestic instability, unsafe environments, emotional distress, social isolation and limited access to economic opportunities.

For many, these circumstances had shaped their livelihood pathways for years.

> *"I had challenges because I had two children, so I couldn't continue."*

For others, the challenge was less about knowing what they wanted to do and more about not seeing a viable way forward.

> *"Before I joined, I had problems; I didn't know what I could do."*

This is an important starting point for livelihood programming. Unemployment is not experienced in isolation from the rest of people's lives. The ability to look for work, start a business, access training or pursue an opportunity is shaped by the social, emotional and material conditions in which people live.

What changed

The earliest and most consistent changes reported by participants were often not changes in their income. They were changes in confidence, social connection, motivation, purpose and the ability to see a future.

These changes are valuable because they appear to create the conditions for participants to pursue economic opportunities more actively.

Confidence and self-belief | **Social connection** | **Purpose and future orientation** | **Emotional resilience**

Confidence and self-belief

> *"I see myself as a success story; I am not going to underestimate myself."*
>
> – PARTICIPANT 4

> *"I'm a shy person, but I've grown to be confident about myself."*
>
> – PARTICIPANT 44

Participants described becoming more confident in speaking, participating, pursuing opportunities and seeing themselves as capable of making decisions about their futures.

Social connection

> *"Before…I was just a person who would lock myself in my room. Now every now and then I'm out socialising with the other participants."*
>
> – PARTICIPANT 6

Participation in groups created connection, encouragement and shared learning. For some participants, simply becoming part of a group represented a significant change from isolation.



"I'm facing the right direction now. I just want to see myself better. I want to see myself improve."

– PARTICIPANT 6

Purpose and future orientation

"It gave me purpose because I have something to look forward to."

– PARTICIPANT 3

Participants described moving from uncertainty and self-doubt towards clearer goals and a greater sense of possibility.

Emotional resilience

"I'm not saying now I'm not struggling, but the struggle is better...if you are happy emotionally... then material things are minor things."

– PARTICIPANT 45

The programme did not remove the difficulties participants were facing. Some described being better able to cope with those difficulties and remain engaged with their goals. These outcomes should not be treated as secondary to economic outcomes because they are an important part of the pathway towards them.

Three participant journeys

Individual experiences make the broader findings more tangible. These three accounts also show that progression is not uniform.

PARTICIPANT 47

SEBOKENG, GAUTENG

Participant 47 – Sebokeng, Gauteng

Before joining GBL, Participant 47 relied on others and had little experience navigating institutions such as the NYDA. The Linkages Facilitator helped her through the funding and registration process, including practical tasks such as completing forms.

That support contributed to a livestock and vegetable business. She now generates her own income, has opened a savings account and is planning her next investment.

"I stopped relying on people… I'm able to pay my own bills currently. And I can talk about money without getting cold feet."

– PARTICIPANT 47

Having a Linkages Facilitator alongside her helped this participant navigate the path to a funding opportunity. With access to a government-funded programme and ongoing practical support, she was able to take that opportunity forward as a meaningful step towards a livelihood.



PARTICIPANT 6

MELODING, FREE STATE

Participant 6 – Meloding, Free State

Participant 6 described his life before GBL as withdrawn and isolated.

"I was reckless…I even sold my car just to get money."

Through sustained participation and peer connection, he described becoming more future-oriented and financially disciplined. He reported saving, providing for his children and becoming more open to opportunities.

"I'm facing the right direction now. I just want to see myself better. I want to see myself improve."

– PARTICIPANT 6

His experience illustrates how changes in confidence, connection and outlook can form part of the pathway towards economic participation.

PARTICIPANT 28

MADADENI, KWAZULU-NATAL

Participant 28 – Madadeni, KwaZulu-Natal

Participant 28 offers an important counterpoint. She valued the programme and remained engaged, but continued to face a local economy where opportunities were limited.

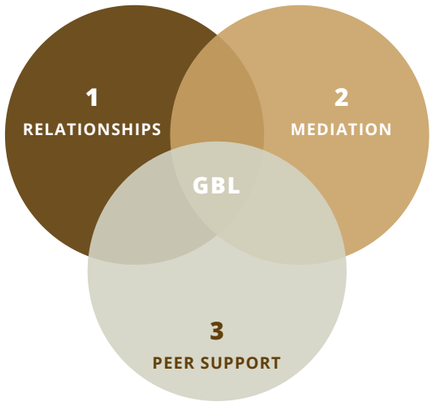
"You can have ideas and skills, but if there are no opportunities around you, it becomes difficult."

– PARTICIPANT 28

This is perhaps the simplest expression of one of the central findings. Skills and motivation are necessary, but they are not enough when the opportunity structure is weak.

What made the difference?

Three features of the GBL model stand out across the interviews.



1. Relationships

Participants experienced GBL through relationships.

Participants described linkages facilitators and champions as people who encouraged them, followed up, explained processes, helped solve problems, and, in some cases, simply listened.

"Having someone who listens and checks on you" became important in sustaining participation.

Participants also described very practical forms of support:

"They help us every step…from filling forms if we are unable to."

This matters because many participants were navigating institutions and processes that were unfamiliar to them.

"Even though Sis' Phililе helps with applications, you still have to go back and forth…you must keep trying until you succeed."

– PARTICIPANT 27

The role was therefore more than motivational. The relationship helped participants navigate the system.

2. Mediation between people and opportunities

GBL increased participants' exposure to training, funding, employment, learnership and entrepreneurship opportunities. Exposure was only the first step.

Participants often needed help to identify relevant opportunities, complete applications, register businesses, submit documents, open accounts, attend workshops and engage with institutions.



KNOWING AN OPPORTUNITY EXISTS — BEING ABLE TO ACCESS IT

"GBL is bridging that gap to get us closer to those things so that we can get information."

This highlights an important distinction between knowing that an opportunity exists and being able to access it. The Linkages Facilitator and Champion roles helped bridge that gap.

3. Peer support

Participants also valued the opportunity to learn alongside others.

"When I saw that there were participants taking charge of their lives…it was motivation to me…if they can do it, I also can do it."

– PARTICIPANT 44

Peer relationships provided encouragement and a sense that progress was possible.

This is particularly important where participants' previous experience may have been one of isolation or limited expectations.

From support to livelihood activity

The changes participants reported extended beyond confidence and social connection.

Participants described:

- Greater awareness of training, funding, employment and entrepreneurship opportunities;
- Improved financial literacy, including budgeting, saving and distinguishing needs from wants;
- Access to business development, agricultural and vocational training;
- Greater ability to navigate institutions;
- Stronger social connection and reduced isolation;
- Renewed motivation and future orientation; and
- Movement into livelihood activities including poultry farming, gardening, sewing, food production and small enterprise activity.

For some, institutional linkages translated into tangible resources.

NYDA GRANT

R45,000

"NYDA gave me a R45,000 grant. I was then able to purchase some [egg] layers, a cage and feed."

For others, training created a new opportunity to participate economically.

"The agricultural training really helped me because it was my first time planting vegetables."

These examples illustrate the potential of combining exposure, mediation and practical support.



Entrepreneurship: Ambition meets reality

Many participants were already trying to generate income before joining GBL.

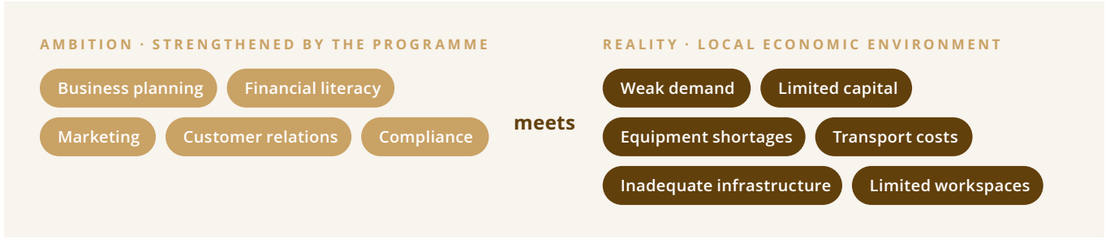
The programme strengthened knowledge of business planning, financial literacy, marketing, customer relations and compliance. But participants continued to operate within difficult local economic environments.

Weak demand, limited capital, equipment shortages, transport costs, inadequate infrastructure and limited workspaces all affected what businesses could achieve.

"I have always been someone who is into business. Since I explained my situation, I saw that I wouldn't get hired anywhere because I am uneducated."

"It wasn't easy before...I didn't have much machines that I was looking for."

This is an important distinction. Not every challenge is due to a lack of entrepreneurial ambition. Often, it is the lack of an environment in which that ambition can translate into a viable livelihood.



What continues to constrain progress?

The research does not only identify what worked. It also shows where progress remains difficult.

Weak local economies · **Material constraints** · **Household pressures** · **Digital and administrative barriers** · **Psychosocial pressures**

Weak local economies

Participants described high unemployment, closed factories, weak local markets and saturated informal economies. For many, the challenge was not finding a better job. It was finding any job at all.

Material constraints

Transport and data costs, limited capital, equipment shortages, and limited access to land, water and workspace all affected participants' ability to act on opportunities.

"I get assistance when I have to go buy feed for the chickens so they can help me with that, so I don't spend money on delivery."

– PARTICIPANT 16

(for participants operating at a very small scale, transport costs can have a significant impact on livelihood income)

Household pressures

Participants were pursuing livelihood opportunities while still dealing with poverty, caregiving responsibilities and food insecurity.

"We depend on the SRD grant."

"We received food parcels for six months straight... it really played a big role."

Livelihood progression therefore takes place alongside immediate survival needs. It does not happen after those needs have disappeared.

Digital and administrative barriers

Digital exclusion, data costs and unfamiliarity with institutional processes limited participants' ability to pursue opportunities independently. This is another reason why information alone is not enough.

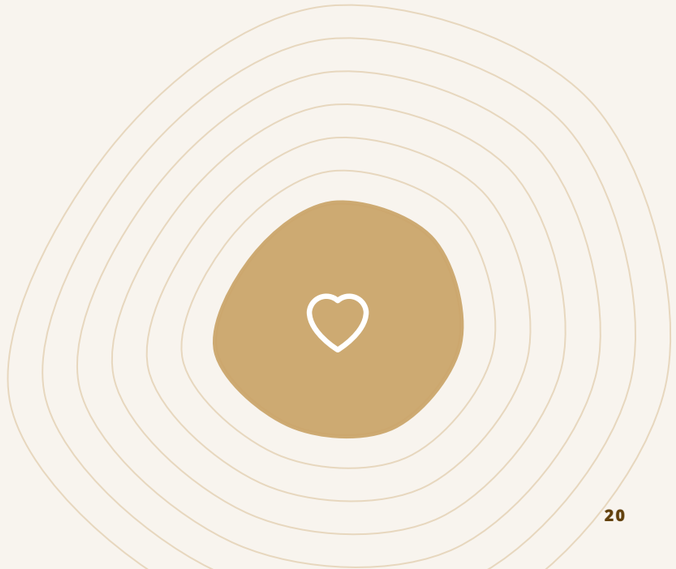
Psychosocial pressures

Emotional distress, prior trauma, isolation and uncertainty affected participants' readiness and ability to sustain engagement.

These realities reinforce the importance of building psychosocial support into livelihood programming.

IN A PARTICIPANT'S WORDS

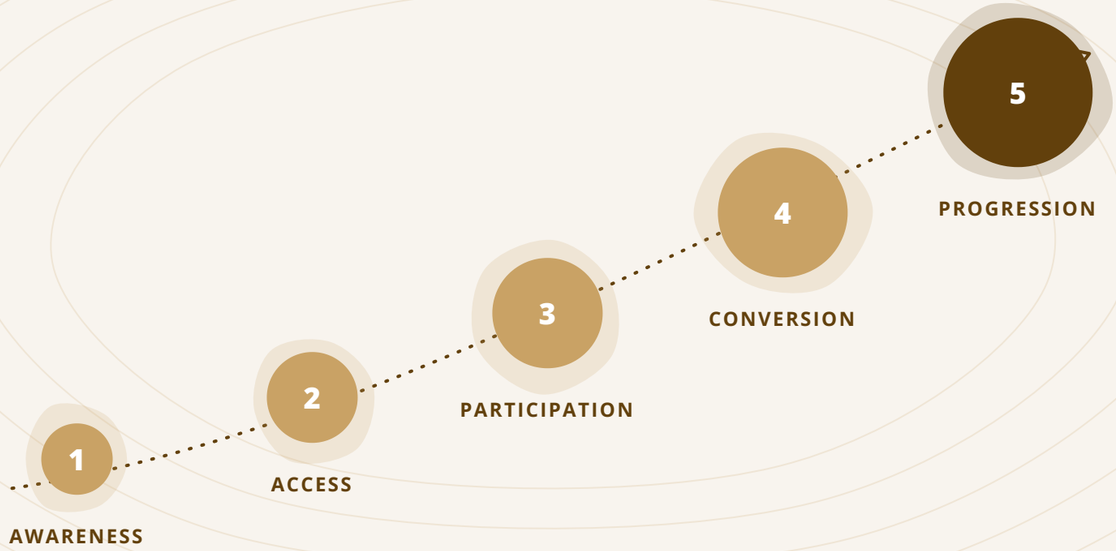
"I was a victim of rape. I got raped and I never got any help. I went to clinics and whatsoever...But they never helped me. And then it repeated...do you know when they say a history can repeat itself over and over again?... And it did happen maybe several times. The last rape, it was in 2023, 2024 when I was looking for a job."



Opportunity needs a pathway

The findings point to a simple but important progression:

AWARENESS → ACCESS → PARTICIPATION → CONVERSION → PROGRESSION



A participant may know about an opportunity but not know how to access it. They may access it but lack the resources to participate. They may participate but be unable to convert that participation into income or sustainable livelihood activity.

Even where income is generated, progress may remain fragile if household pressures, weak markets or material constraints persist. The role of GBL is therefore to help participants move through the pathway from opportunity to action and, ultimately, towards greater economic agency.



What this means for the GBL model

The evidence points to nine areas that matter if the model is to be institutionalised or scaled.

1

Make relational support part of the model

Relationships should not depend on individual goodwill or be treated as an informal addition to the programme. The role of frontline staff, their caseloads, skills and support need to be deliberately designed.

2

Treat psychosocial support as foundational

Confidence, emotional resilience and social connection often precede livelihood progression. They should therefore form part of the programme architecture and measurement framework.

3

Focus on conversion, not just exposure

The question should not only be whether participants were referred to an opportunity. It should be whether they were able to act on it.

4

Design for local economies

The same intervention will not produce the same results everywhere. Local labour markets, enterprise opportunities and institutional capacity matter.

5

Differentiate participant pathways

Participants arrive with different levels of education, confidence, household responsibility, experience and readiness. A single pathway will not work equally well for everyone.

6

Address practical barriers

Transport, data, childcare, equipment, capital, land and other practical constraints can determine whether a participant can take advantage of an opportunity.

7

Stay with participants for longer

Once-off referrals and short training interventions are unlikely to be sufficient for participants facing multiple and overlapping barriers. Continued accompaniment matters.

8

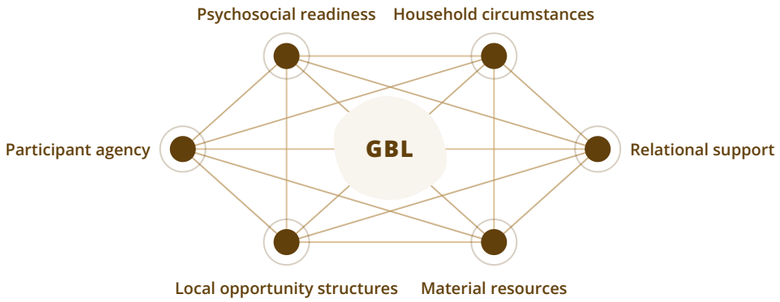
Measure more than employment

Employment and income remain important. But so are confidence, agency, social participation, future orientation and capability. These can provide important signals of progression before material outcomes become visible.

9

Recognise that outcomes are interconnected

Participant agency, psychosocial readiness, household circumstances, relational support, material resources and local opportunity structures interact.



There is therefore no single lever that can explain success.

What this means for continued investment

The value of this evidence lies partly in its honesty.

It includes participants who progressed and participants who struggled. It identifies meaningful changes while also showing where the programme cannot, on its own, overcome the realities of local economies, poverty and limited resources.

That gives us three clear priorities for continued investment.

1 Invest in the relationships

If relational support is one of the mechanisms through which opportunities become accessible, it needs to be properly resourced.

That means thinking about frontline capacity, caseloads, training, supervision and the role of Linkage Facilitators and Champions.

2 Invest in the ecosystem around participants

Participant motivation is not enough to create jobs, functioning markets or productive resources.

The next phase, therefore, needs to look beyond the participant and strengthen the opportunity ecosystem around them – including institutional pathways, local markets, and access to productive resources.

3 Measure the whole journey

If the pathway to livelihood progression is longer than a single referral or training intervention, our measurement needs to reflect that.

We should be able to see where participants are progressing, where they are getting stuck and what is preventing them from moving forward.

That means tracking economic outcomes alongside changes in confidence, agency, social participation, future orientation, capability and ability to navigate institutions.

The overall lesson

“I’m facing the right direction now. I just want to see myself better. I want to see myself improve.”



The GBL research concludes that livelihoods are built through relationships, resources and opportunities. Participants need access to opportunities, but they also need someone to help them navigate those opportunities, the confidence to act, practical support to overcome barriers and time to make progress.

At the same time, the evidence reminds us that relationships cannot substitute for functioning opportunity structures.

For this reason, the next phase of GBL should build on what the evidence shows works, while addressing the conditions that continue to limit progress.

The opportunity is to develop a livelihood support model that is relational at the frontline, responsive to participants’ different circumstances, connected to real economic opportunities and able to measure progress across the full pathway.

This is the more important lesson from the pilot – and the basis on which the model can be strengthened for institutionalisation and scale.

“I am pursuing, and I am determined to see myself where I want to be in this life.”

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